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‘Could you send us your latest catalogue?’: A local grammar of requesting in English business letters

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ABSTRACT

This study introduces a local grammar approach to investigating discourse acts in English business texts, demonstrating this with the discourse act of requesting in English business letters. Previous studies on request language in business letters have focused on its pragmatic, rhetorical, and lexical features, paying less attention to the exploration of how concrete meanings are expressed in making requests. Based on a one-million-word English business correspondence corpus, this study adopts a local grammar approach to analyze the semantic patterns for requesting. The results show that requesting in English business letters involves eight specific meanings, forming 16 semantic patterns, i.e. local grammar patterns. These patterns represent the most typical ways of meaning expression for request making in English business letter writing in an easy-to-read and systematic manner, demonstrating local grammar’s added methodological value for exploring characteristic patterning of language in ESP/EBP (English for Business Purposes) contexts. The findings of this study can also provide important pedagogical insights for improving ESP/EBP learners’ pragmatic competence.
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1. Introduction

This paper reports on a corpus-based local grammar study for the investigation of discourse acts in the English for Business Purposes (EBP) context. English business texts, especially English business letters, involve the performing of a number of discourse acts. Some of them, such as requesting, thanking, and apologizing, are frequently seen in other communicative contexts. Others, like inquiry, offer, and confirmation of acceptance, are more characteristic of the business contexts. In this study, we focus on a particular discourse act of requesting to clearly demonstrate the methodological value of local grammar for ESP/EBP research.

Requesting is “an attempt by the speaker to get the hearer to do something”, the purpose of which, is to “involve the hearer in some future action that matches the speaker’s goal” (Usó-Juan, 2010, p. 238). Due to its high frequency in daily communication (Aijmer, 1996, p. 125) and its involvement of complicated pragmatic and social factors such as politeness and face-threatening effect (Brown & Levinson, 1987; Yao, Song, & Sheng, 2021), requesting, especially its linguistic realization, i.e. the

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request language, has long been the concern of linguistic research, especially pragmatic research (Chen, He, & Hu, 2013; Drew & Couper-Kuhlen, 2014; Liu & Wang, 2022; Saito & Cook, 2018; Searle, 1969; Trosborg, 1995; Zhou, 2019). Most of these studies, as reviewed in Drew and Couper-Kuhlen (2014) and Saito and Cook (2018), tended to take a cross-cultural perspective to explore the linguistic/cultural variations of the request language (e.g. Chen et al., 2013) or a language acquisition perspective to look into L2 learners' development of the pragmatic competence of request making (e.g. Trosborg, 1995; Zhou, 2019).

Requesting occurs in a wide range of contexts, including daily conversation, TV interviews, court debate, and business negotiation, to name only a few. Among them, business correspondence provides a suitable and interesting test bed to investigate requesting. This is because, firstly, requesting is a highly frequently performed discourse act in business letters (Chen, 2007; Ho, 2018) since business transactions always involve the provision and sharing of a large amount of data and information. The two sides of the transactions need to repeatedly ask for information/deeds to ensure that transactions proceed smoothly (Pilegaard, 1997, p. 224). Secondly, making requests in business letters is a speech act realized in written form (hence a discourse act). The strict demand for high level of formality of language use in business correspondence (Aimoldina, Zharkynbekova, & Akynova, 2016; Chen, 2003) tends to complicate the linguistic realizations of this discourse act. Thirdly, requesting in business letters often involves many cross linguistic/cultural factors as the two parties in business letters often come from different countries. A lack of consideration of the cultural-specific pragmatic principles in request making may threaten the other party's face, damage corporate image, and even ruin business relationships (Park, Jeon, & Shim, 2021, p. 138).

More importantly, making appropriate requests in real communication can be rather challenging for learners of English. As Usó-Juan (2010) notes, "learners need to possess considerable pragmatic expertise in order to be able to perform requests successfully" (p. 237). Studies in second language acquisition (SLA) (e.g. Aimoldina et al., 2016; Economidou-Kogetsidis, 2011; Maier, 1992) also show that L2 business letter writers demonstrate many difficulties in making appropriate and acceptable requests. For example, Aimoldina et al. (2016) observed that Kazakhstani business letter writers have difficulties in accurately and idiomatically express requests in English business letters: First, their requesting expressions are rather direct and imperative (e.g. *Did you get my project?* and *I need to know*); Second, they show a dominant preference for active voice (e.g. *You promised to complete the project outline within a week*) (p. 67). This indicates that the current English business letter writing teaching may have some problems which affect learners' expression of meanings to effectively perform discourse acts and in turn hinder their pragmatic competence development in ESP/EBP contexts. Given the above-mentioned characteristics of requesting in business letters and ESP learners' difficulty in effective expression of requests, a specialized investigation of this discourse act is warranted to systematically represent its linguistic resources so as to facilitate the teaching and learning of this business discourse act.

The review of the literature showed that the research on requesting in business letters mainly follows four approaches: First, the pragmatic approach (e.g. Pilegaard, 1997; Yeung, 1997) which concentrates on the analysis of the use of concrete strategies and principles for request making based on Brown and Levinson's (1987) politeness theory. Second, the genre analysis approach in which researchers (e.g. Park et al., 2021; Richard & McFadden, 2016) exclusively explore the generic features of business request letters. Third, the SLA approach in which studies (e.g. Aimoldina et al., 2016; Maier, 1992) focus on L2 learners' development of pragmatic competence based on the investigation of the pragmatic features in L2 business letter writers' language of request. Fourth, the metadiscourse approach (e.g. Ho, 2018) which observes the metadiscourse resources for request making in the corpora of business letters. It can be noted that the above-mentioned approaches mainly focus on the analyses of the pragmatic, rhetorical, and lexical features of business letter request language. None of them has attempted to investigate the specific functions/meanings that are used to realize requesting, let alone explore the semantic patterns of requesting based on the study of its authentic phraseologies in large corpora of English business letters. These semantic patterns or resources, we argue, might be of more practical communicative value for learners to effectively make requests in business letters. Drawing insights from Su's (2017) semantic analyses of requesting in dramatic dialogue from a 'local grammar' (Hunston & Sinclair, 2000) perspective, this study sets out to use this meaning-oriented local grammar approach in corpus linguistics to analyze the semantic patterns of the request language in English business letters. It will demonstrate how the local grammar approach can more effectively capture the functional/semantic elements in a specific business discourse act than other grammar approaches. Moreover, the findings of this study are expected to provide important pedagogical insights for developing learners' pragmatic competence for performing discourse acts in ESP/EBP contexts.

2. Local grammar

Local grammar emerges from corpus linguistic research. It is "an approach of linguistic research which focuses on the description of the meanings and functions of particular sets of language" (Su & Wei, 2022, p. 804). Local grammar has three distinctive methodological features (see also Zhang & Wei, 2018, pp. 111–112). First, focused perspective: Each local grammar concentrates on the description of only one discourse act or communicative function for exhaustive description. Second, meaning-oriented description: The core content of local grammar analysis is to describe the semantic realizations of discourse acts or communicative functions. Third, lexis-based analysis: Local grammar is a lexis-driven grammar which conducts semantic analyses on the lexical resources of discourse acts or communicative functions.

Local grammar analysis includes three key steps: First, retrieval of instances of discourse acts from corpora. For example, in Zhang and Su's (2022) local grammar of definition, instances of definition were retrieved from a corpus of linguistics research

articles based on the lexical markers of definition such as *term*, *refer*, and *that is*. Second, identification of local grammar terminologies. As in Zhang and Su (2022, p. 6), terminologies like 'Definiendum' (i.e. the term or concept that is being defined), 'Definiens' (i.e. the element that indicates how the term or concept is defined), and 'Source-internal' (i.e. the author who makes the definition) were identified from the instances of definition. Third, local grammar analyses by form-meaning mappings to produce local grammar patterns. As represented in Zhang and Su's (2022) analyses (see Table 1 for example), a definition sentence *Misformation refers to the choice of an inappropriate form of the lemma* was analyzed by matching each structural element in the sentence with a specific local grammar terminology (e.g. *Misformation* matches 'Definiendum'). This produced a local grammar pattern 'Definiendum + Hinge + Definiens' which represents the semantic pattern/regularity of a group of definition sentences. When all the instances were analyzed into a set of local grammar patterns, a local grammar of definition was established.

Earlier local grammar studies (e.g. Barnbrook, 2002; Cheng & Ching, 2018; Hunston & Su, 2019; Su & Zhang, 2020; Zhang, Jiang, & Zhang, 2024) have commonly demonstrated that for many discourse acts in different text types (e.g. definition in dictionaries, disclaimer in business discourse, graphic data commentary in academic discourse), local grammar can provide a more precise and systematic description of their semantic patterns for different groups of language users than general grammars.

Su (2017) attempted to use local grammar to analyze the semantic patterns of the request language in a corpus of dramatic dialogue in the famous TV drama 'The Big Bang Theory' (CBBT). Based on previous studies, Su collected 11 collocational patterns for requesting, such as I/we WANT you to-inf., can/could/will/would you VP, etc., and retrieved instances of requesting (e.g. *We want you to keep it*, *Could you drive me home?*) in CBBT. Upon the retrieved instances, Su identified seven functional terminologies for requesting, such as 'Requester' (i.e. the person who makes requests), 'Requestee' (i.e. the person who is requested), and 'Requested action' (i.e. the action that the Requester wants the Requestee to perform). These terminologies were then matched with their corresponding structural elements in the instances of requesting to produce local grammar patterns. As illustrated in Table 2, Su analyzed instances like *We want you to keep it* and *I want you to apologize to Leonard* as the local grammar pattern 'Requester + Hinge + Requestee + Requested action', revealing the semantic pattern/regularity of one group of instances of requesting. If we compare the local grammar analysis with the traditional grammar analysis (as illustrated in Table 2), traditional grammar analyzes the two requesting sentences as the pattern 'Subject + Verb + Object', with each structural element matching a grammatical functional category (e.g. Subject). The same analysis can be applied for the instances of many other discourse acts such as thanking (e.g. *We thank you*) or exemplifying (e.g. *The following examples illustrate the different types of attempted paraphrases*). By contrast, local grammar uses more context-specific descriptive terminologies special for requesting (e.g. 'Requester', 'Requestee'). This enables a deeper functional/semantic analysis of requesting and a clearer and more precise description of what specific functions and meanings are used to realize this discourse act.

In view of local grammar's precise and context-specific description of the semantic patterns of discourse acts, we argue that this approach can be used to analyze business discourse acts. To our knowledge, although local grammar research has developed rapidly in recent years, it has been rarely applied to address business language. Given this, this study attempts to use the local grammar approach to analyze a typical business discourse act of requesting in English business letters. It intends to demonstrate that local grammar can provide an effective alternative for the investigation of characteristic features of language use in ESP/EBP discourses. Meanwhile, we argue that our local grammar study can also contribute pedagogical insights for ESP/EBP teaching.

3. Methodology

3.1. Corpus

The research corpus in this study is the online Business Letter Corpus (BLC hereafter)[1] established by Japanese corpus researcher Yasumasa Someya in 1990s (around 1992–1999). This corpus was compiled as part of his MA thesis (Someya, 1999) and has been widely used in many other studies (e.g. Flowerdew, 2012; Someya, 2000). Specifically, the corpus collected 11,610 paper and electronic business letters (including inquiry letters, request letters, invitation letters, etc.) written by British and American business professionals, amounting to 1,020,060 English words (see also Someya, 2000 for the detailed introduction of the design of this corpus). We visited this corpus and collected data from it from October 2nd to October 20th, 2021.

Table 1
Demonstration of local grammar analyses of definition (Zhang & Su, 2022, p. 7).

Definiendum	Hinge	Definiens
Misformation	refers to	the choice of an inappropriate form of the lemma

[1] Originally, the website of the online corpus was http://www.someya-net.com/concordancer/. Regrettably, the website did not provide service since 2022. We retrieved the data from the corpus in 2021 and performed local grammar analyses based on the data.

Table 2
Comparison of local grammar analyses and traditional grammar analyses of requesting.

Local grammar analysis	Requester	Hinge	Requestee	Requested action
Traditional grammar analysis	**Subject**	**Verb**	**Object**	
	We	want	you	to keep it
	I	want	you	to apologize to Leonard

3.2. Working procedure

We took the following three steps to perform the local grammar analyses.

3.2.1. Retrieval of instances

Based on the 11 collocational patterns of requesting listed in Su (2017) (see Table 3), we searched each one of them in BLC to obtain instances of requesting.

Take 'I/we WANT to-inf.' as an example. As this collocational pattern corresponds to four different phrases, including *I want to*, *we want to*, *I wanted to*, and *we wanted to*, we searched all the four phrases in BLC to obtain a group of instances. As Figure 1 shows, we first searched the phrase *I want to* in the corpus and it returned 152 hits.

Table 3
Collocational patterns of requesting (Su, 2017, p. 75).

	Collocational patterns
Direct requests	Imperatives
	You HAVE[a] to-inf./must VP[b]
	I/we WANT you to-inf.
	I/we WANT to-inf.
	I/we'd/would like to-inf.
	I/we wonder if you could VP
Indirect requests	Can/could/will/would you VP
	Would/do you mind VP
	Can/could/may I/we VP
	Would you like to-inf.
	Would you like me to-inf.

[a] Capital letters indicate lemmas.
[b] VP stands for verb phrase.

This was followed by a close reading of the instances to filter out those which do not perform requesting. This manual reading allowed us to obtain 33 qualified instances of requesting, such as *I want to meet at your convenience* and *We want to make some copy changes*.

We improved Su's (2017) way of instance collection,[2] using a regular expression '[A-Z]\w+_VB\s' to retrieve imperative requests in the part-of-speech-annotated BLC. This added 734 instances (e.g. *Bring this letter on your first visit*) into our instance reservoir.

3.2.2. Instance reading and terminology identification

A closer reading of the instances enabled us to summarize a set of meanings closely associated with requesting. As in the instance *We want to make some copy changes*, we summarized three meanings including "The person or organization who makes requests" (corresponding to *We*), "The element that links different elements" (corresponding to *want to*), and "The action that the Requester him/herself wants to perform" (corresponding to *make some copy changes*). Drawing on the naming method in Su (2017), we further identified eight local grammar terminologies from these repeatedly occurring meanings (see Table 4).

3.2.3. Local grammar analyses

We performed local grammar analyses by matching each structure element (with an intact meaning) in each instance with a particular terminology in Table 4. As shown in Table 5, instances with a similar meaning expression sequence such as *Would you please consider me for that project* and *Can you provide the following equipment* were analyzed as follows: the initial phrase which signals the occurrence of requesting (e.g. *would you*) was analyzed as 'Indicator'. The following optional element which weakens the force of the requesting (e.g. *please*) was termed as '(Mitigator)'.[3] The ending verb phrase (e.g. *consider me* …)

[2] Su did not specially retrieve the imperative instances (e.g. *Take the cap off*), but put them into a particular group based on general manual reading and analyzed them uniformly as a local grammar pattern 'Requested action' (see Su, 2017, p. 76).
[3] The parentheses indicate that the element is optional in the instances.

Figure 1. Demonstration of the instance retrieval process.

Table 4
Local grammar terminologies of requesting in English business letters.

Terminology	Definition	Example
Requester	The person or organization who makes requests	***I*** want to confirm our mutual understanding
Indicator	The element that signals the occurrence of a request	***Could we*** get together sometime early next week
Requestee	The person or organization who is being requested	I want ***you*** to begin reviewing your files
Requested action	The action to be performed by the requestee under the request of the requester	Can you ***arrange a meeting next week***
Intended action	The action that the requester him/herself wants to perform	We would like to ***begin the contract in April***
Joint action	The action performed by both the requester and the requestee	Let's ***get reacquainted***
Mitigator	The element that mitigates the face-threatening effect of requests	Would you ***please*** enclose the following documents
Hinge	The element that links different elements	You ***have to*** review your current expenses carefully

realizes an action performed by the person under request, thus was termed as 'Requested action'. The analytical procedure produced a local grammar pattern 'Indicator + (Mitigator) + Requested action'. The frequency information shows that this pattern is realized by 209 instances in the corpus. Following this way, we analyzed all the instances of requesting into a group of local grammar patterns, establishing a local grammar of requesting in English business letters.

4. Results

This section demonstrates the results of the local grammar analyses, revealing how each local grammar pattern was produced and how typical it is in the corpus. We report the patterns which have at least two instances in the corpus.

As shown in Table 6, the most frequent local grammar pattern of requesting in our corpus is 'Requested action', covering 542 instances of requesting in the corpus. This pattern asks for an action from the other party in a most direct and concise manner.

Pattern 'Indicator + (Mitigator) + Requested action' is realized by 209 instances, the analyses of which are demonstrated in Table 5 above. This pattern takes an interrogative structure, which corresponds to indirect requests (Su, 2017). By using this pattern, business letter writers make requests in a consultative tone, the use of 'Mitigator' further weakening the tone.

The analyses of 167 instances produced the pattern 'Indicator + Intended action'. As Table 7 shows, the initial phrase (e.g. *May I*) which signals the occurrence of a request was labelled as 'Indicator'. The following content (e.g. *have a copy of* …) indicates an action that the requester wants to perform, thus was termed as 'Intended action'. Functionally, this pattern is characterized by taking the perspective of the requester himself/herself to earnestly demand for the other party's behavior, permission, or recognition.

The pattern 'Requester + Hinge + Intended action' in Table 8 corresponds to 143 instances. In this group of instances, the initial pronoun (e.g. *We*) realizes 'Requester'. The following verb phrase (e.g. *want to*) hinges it with another verb phrase (e.g. *serve you* …) which indicates the requester's 'Intended action'. Compared with 'Indicator + Intended action', 'Requester + Hinge + Intended action' more directly expresses demands or claims, which is more likely to threaten the face.

98 instance were analyzed as 'Indicator + Joint action' (see Table 9). The initial phrase (e.g. *Could we*) indicates the occurrence of the request. The pronoun in this phrase (e.g. *we*) further signals that the following action is a 'Joint action'

Table 5
Demonstration of local grammar analyses of requesting.

Indicator	(Mitigator)	Requested action	Frequency = 209
Would you	please	consider me for that project	
Can you		provide the following equipment	

Table 6
Pattern 'Requested action'.

Requested action	Frequency = 542
Take a look at the catalogue and see what there is	
Include a brief description of each project	

Table 7
Pattern 'Indicator + Intended action'.

Indicator	Intended action	Frequency = 167
May I	have a copy of your reproduction when it is ready for distribution	
Let us	know when you are ready	

Table 8
Pattern 'Requester + Hinge + Intended action'.

Requester	Hinge	Intended action	Frequency = 143
We	want to	serve you for all your future furniture needs	
I	would like to	apply for the position of sales assistant	

Table 9
Pattern 'Indicator + Joint action'.

Indicator	Joint action	Frequency = 98
Could we	get together to give some serious thought to my career plans	
May we	talk again in the next few months	

conducted by both the requester and the requestee (e.g. *get together* …). The requester uses this pattern with the intention of sincere cooperation between both parties to achieve a common goal.

Table 10 shows the analyses of 36 instances which produced the pattern 'Requestee + Hinge + Requested action'. Specifically, the initial pronoun (e.g. *You*) points to the person under request, thus was analyzed as 'Requestee'. The following modal verb (e.g. *must*) functions as 'Hinge', introducing the 'Requested action' (e.g. *attend all five sessions* …). This pattern makes a request from the perspective of the requestee, suggesting or demanding for the requestee's action. The use of forceful modal verbs (e.g. *must*, *should*) reminds the other party of the necessity and urgency of completing the task under discussion.

The analyses of 19 instances produced a pattern 'Requester + Hinge + Intended action + Requestee + Requested action' (see Table 11). This complicated pattern involves five meaning elements. Unlike the pattern 'Requester + Hinge + Intended action', this pattern contains an 'Intended action' (e.g. *ask*) whose real intention is to ask the requestee (e.g. *you*) to perform an action (e.g. *contact us*).

As demonstrated in Table 12, 17 instances were uniformly analyzed as 'Requester + Hinge + Requestee + Requested action'. It differs from the pattern 'Requester + Hinge + Intended action + Requestee + Requested action' in the absence of 'Intended action'. This absence makes the requests directly point to the other party's action, thus are more direct, straightforward, and face-threatening.

The pattern 'Indicator + Intended action + (Requestee) + Requested action' presented in Table 13 covers 16 instances. It can be seen as a variant of the pattern 'Requester + Hinge + Intended action + Requestee + Requested action' (see Table 11). The interrogative form makes the requests less forceful, the consultative tone weakening the face-threatening effect of the requests.

9 instances were analyzed as 'Requester + Hinge + Requested action' (see Table 14). In this pattern, 'Hinge' is uniformly realized by the verb *wonder*. The following clause led by *if* functions to inquire about the other party's willingness or ability to perform a particular action, thus was termed as 'Requested action'. Compared with 'Requester + Hinge + Requestee + Requested action', this pattern leaves the requestee more space for consideration, a more polite way to make requests.

Table 10
Pattern 'Requestee + Hinge + Requested action'.

Requestee	Hinge	Requested action	Frequency = 36
You	must	attend all five sessions to receive training credit	
You	have to	review your current expenses carefully	

Table 11
Pattern 'Requester + Hinge + Intended action + Requestee + Requested action'.

Requester	Hinge	Intended action	Requestee	Requested action	Frequency = 19
We	would like to	ask	you	to contact us	
I	would like to	ask	you	to press forward with this work without any further delay	

Table 12
Pattern 'Requester + Hinge + Requestee + Requested action'.

Requester	Hinge	Requestee	Requested action	Frequency = 17
We	want	you	to come	
I	want	you	to see for yourself how your customers will respond to our pieces.	

Table 13
Pattern 'Indicator + Intended action + (Requestee) + Requested action'.

Indicator	Intended action	(Requestee)	Requested action	Frequency = 16
May I	ask	you	to inform your colleagues of this letter	
May we	count on		your presence	

Table 14
Pattern 'Requester + Hinge + Requested action'.

Requester	Hinge	Requested action	Frequency = 9
We	wonder	if you would confirm the current position	
I	wonder	if you could give some consideration to Mr. Kataoka's proposal	

Table 15 shows the analyses of 6 instances: The initial phrase (e.g. *Would you*) is an 'Initiator', showing an inquiring tone. The subsequent verb phrase (e.g. *allow us*) points to the requestee's permission of the requester's action, which could be analyzed as 'Requested action' and 'Requester'. The ending infinitive phrase indicates the requester's action under the permission of the requestee, thus was analyzed as 'Intended action'. This pattern 'Indicator + Requested action + Requester + Intended action' manifests the requester's humble attitude to obtain the other party's permission to get things done.

Another 6 instances could be analyzed in the way Table 16 shows. The initial *Please* was termed as 'Mitigator', followed by a phrase (e.g. *will you*) realizing 'Indicator'. The subsequent verb phrase indicates a 'Requested action' to be performed by the requestee. By highlighting 'Mitigator', this pattern enables business letter writers to express an earnest attitude in request making.

In the imperative instances of requesting, four of them could be analyzed as 'Intended action' (see Table 17). A close reading of the contexts showed that this group of requests is between colleagues within one company (group) to encourage closer cooperation and higher efficiency.

Another four instances which take the imperative form were analyzed as 'Requested action + Requester + Intended action' (see Table 18). It can be seen as a variant of the pattern 'Indicator + Requested action + Requester + Intended action'. The omission of 'Indicator' enhances the formality and seriousness of the requests.

Six instances led by *May I* were analyzed as two different local grammar patterns: 'Indicator + Intended action + Joint action' (see Table 19) and 'Indicator + Intended action + Requested action' (see Table 20). Their only difference lies in the

Table 15
Pattern 'Indicator + Requested action + Requester + Intended action'.

Indicator	Requested action	Requester	Intended action	Frequency = 6
Would you	allow	us	to use your name as the honorary chairman	
Will you	permit	me	to take the year off to finish school	

Table 16
Pattern 'Mitigator + Indicator + Requested action'.

Mitigator	Indicator	Requested action	Frequency = 6
Please	will you	cable your decision as soon as possible	
Please	would you	return the whole consignment to us	

Table 17
Pattern 'Intended action'.

Intended action	Frequency = 4
Make sure we give a good impression	
Make ourselves available for local demos for PeriPlex's Oakdale customers	

Table 18
Pattern 'Requested action + Requester + Intended action'.

Requested action	Requester	Intended action	Frequency = 4
Permit	me	to tell you exactly what happened.	
Allow	me	to introduce myself as your new reliance industries sales rep	

Table 19
Pattern 'Indicator + Intended action + Joint action'.

Indicator	Intended action	Joint action	Frequency = 3
May I	suggest	we meet at my office on Monday, 3 PM	
may I	suggest	we meet perhaps for a cocktail at the fairfax club on March 6th	

Table 20
Pattern 'Indicator + Intended action + Requested action'.

Indicator	Intended action	Requested action	Frequency = 3
May I, therefore,	suggest	that you print out the attached credit card payment form	
May I	suggest	that you could perhaps make some allowance on your quoted prices	

different meanings following 'Intended action' (e.g. *suggest*): a 'Joint action' in the former (e.g. *we meet at my office* …) and a 'Requested action' in the latter (e.g. *that you print out* …). Making requests in the form of suggestions is a common functional feature of the two patterns.

Based on the analyses from Table 5 to Table 20, we identified 16 local grammar patterns, which together form a local grammar of requesting in English business letters. Table 21 provides a full list of all the 16 patterns and their frequency information.

As can be observed in Table 21, 1,282 instances of requesting were retrieved from BLC (1,257 times per million words) and were analyzed as 16 local grammar patterns. These patterns, with each representing a distinctive way of meaning usage, provide a systematic inventory of the typical lexical-semantic resources for requesting in our research corpus. We will discuss the methodological advantages of local grammar for the analysis of ESP/EBP discourses in Section 5 and provide the pedagogical value of local grammar for developing ESP/EBP learners' pragmatic competence in Section 6.

5. Discussion

A close observation of the local grammar patterns in Table 21 and their corresponding instances of requesting enables us to see more clearly the characteristics of local grammar analysis and its added methodological value for ESP/EBP research.

First, unlike many other grammar approaches which target at language as a whole such as traditional grammar or systemic functional grammar (SFG hereafter), local grammar focuses on one discourse act/communicative function at a time. This simplifies the functional/semantic analysis as many irrelevant functions/meanings have been filtered out when we restrict the analysis to a particular discourse act, especially in a restricted language (e.g. English business letters). As our study shows, only eight functions/meanings of requesting (i.e. local grammar terminologies in Table 4) have been identified in the corpus. These meanings, through our analyses, have been represented as 16 recurrent local grammar patterns for requesting in business letter writing. In this sense, we can say that local grammar provides an easy-to-handle approach for researchers to explore patterning of language in ESP/EBP research.

Second, as local grammar concentrates on the description of the semantic realizations of only one discourse act, its analysis is more targeted and precise (see Table 22 for illustration).

Table 21
Local grammar patterns of requesting in BLC.

No.	Pattern	Example	Raw (normed) frequency
1	Requested action	Place one full-page ad each week	542 (531)
2	Indicator + (Mitigator) + Requested action	Could you please check that the consignment is complete and undamaged?	209 (205)
3	Indicator + Intended action	Would you mind if I quoted the job with packaged music as well as original music?	167 (164)
4	Requester + Hinge + Intended action	We want to celebrate our anniversary with you	143 (140)
5	Indicator + Joint action	Let's get together next week and talk	98 (96)
6	Requestee + Hinge + Requested action	You must help us by responding to our communications	36 (35)
7	Requester + Hinge + Intended action + Requestee + Requested action	I would like to ask you to press forward with this work without any further delay	19 (19)
8	Requester + Hinge + Requestee + Requested action	I want you to see for yourself how your customers will respond to our pieces	17 (17)
9	Indicator + Intended action + (Requestee) + Requested action	May we count on you to consider the exhibit for 19XX or a year later?	16 (16)
10	Requester + Hinge + Requested action	I wonder if you would kindly give us some introductions	9 (9)
11	Indicator + Requested action + Requester + Intended action	Will you forgive me for having to postpone our April 2 meeting?	6 (6)
12	Mitigator + Indicator + Requested action	Please would you send the enclosed draft on J.K.B. Products pry?	6 (6)
13	Intended action	Make sure we give a good impression	4 (4)
14	Requested action + Requester + Intended action	Permit me to tell you exactly what happened	4 (4)
15	Indicator + Intended action + Joint action	May I suggest we meet at my office on Thursday 10AM?	3 (3)
16	Indicator + Intended action + Requested action	May I suggest that you could perhaps make some allowance on your quoted prices	3 (3)
Total			1,282 (1,257)

Table 22
Illustration of local grammar analysis, traditional grammar analysis, and transitivity analysis.

Local grammar analysis	**Requester**	**Hinge**	**Intended action**
	We	want to	make some copy changes
Traditional grammar analysis	**Subject**	**Verb**	**Object**
Transitivity analysis	**Senser**	**Process**	**Phenomenon**
	We	want to	make some copy changes
	I	can feel	something on my foot
	Mark Antony	regretted	the fact that Caesar was dead

As shown in Table 22, an instance of requesting *We want to make some copy changes* can be analyzed as 'Subject + Verb + Object' by the traditional grammar and 'Senser + Process + Phenomenon' by the transitivity analysis in SFG. And the same analysis can be performed on many other sentences which do not realize requesting such as *I can feel something on my foot* or *Mark Antony regretted the fact that Caesar was dead*. This is because neither the traditional grammar nor SFG is designed for analyzing requesting only, which makes their analyses general and context-insensitive. On the other hand, the same sentence *We want to make some copy changes* is analyzed as 'Requester + Hinge + Intended action' by the local grammar of requesting. With the focused perspective, the local grammar's analysis is targeted at requesting only and cannot be applied to the description of other discourse acts. Furthermore, the context-specific analytical terminologies (e.g. 'Requester') enable local grammar to more precisely represent the meaning elements in requesting. In view of this, we argue that local grammar provides researchers a finer-grained and targeted approach to exploring characteristics of language use in ESP/EBP contexts.

Third, local grammar provides a closer view of the link between communicative needs and language resources (i.e. lexical-semantic resources). On the one hand, local grammar patterns directly represent the concrete words/meanings and how they are typically organized to perform a discourse act. On the other hand, our local grammar analyses show that each local grammar pattern suits a particular context (see Section 4). For example, the pattern 'Requestee + Hinge + Requested action'' (e.g. *You must complete this first step*) is suitable for urgent requests, while 'Indicator + Joint action' (e.g. *Can we talk soon?*) caters to the need to emphasize cooperation. The two aspects allow local grammar researchers to see more clearly how language resources are employed for communicating meanings. This also means that local grammar has the potential to better inform ESP/EBP learners of how to deal with concrete communicative situations with meanings and words. As Su (2019) argues, local grammar provides learners a meaning-based grammar of English which documents systematically the lexical-semantic means by which a specific meaning/function can be expressed in real communication.

Fourth, the frequency information of each local grammar pattern suggests that the product of local grammar analyses can be quantified. As shown in Table 21, we have quantified the semantic realizations of requesting in the corpus of English business letters as 16 local grammar patterns. Each local grammar pattern in turn corresponds to a specific number of instances in the corpus. For example, the pattern 'Requested action' has 542 instances in the corpus (531 times per million words), representing the most frequent semantic pattern of requesting in the corpus. This quantification is important as it allows local grammar to provide a more systematic analysis of functions/meanings in ESP/EBP discourses than other grammar approaches. With different ways of meaning expression analyzed as quantified patterns, researchers can more systematically document characteristics and regularities of language use in ESP/EBP texts.

6. Pedagogical implications for developing learners' pragmatic competence in ESP/EBP contexts

Based on the research data and our discussion, we argue that analyzing discourse acts in business contexts from a local grammar perspective has important pedagogical potential to better inform teaching practitioners (e.g. Li, 2012; Qi & Lai, 2017) how to effectively cultivate ESP/EBP learners' pragmatic competence through explicit pedagogical intervention. Pragmatic competence is "the ability to communicate your intended message with all its nuances in any socio-cultural context and to interpret the message of your interlocutor as it was intended" (Fraser, 2010, p. 15). It consists of two subcomponents: pragmalinguistic competence (i.e. language resources at the speakers' disposal to perform discourse acts) and sociopragmatic competence (i.e. the constraints of contextual/social conditions on language use) (Beltrán-Planques & Querol-Julián, 2018; Leech, 1983; Thomas, 1983). To realize this, we suggest integrating three teaching steps into specific ESP/EBP classes.

Step 1: Raising learners' awareness of business discourse acts

In the first step, the teacher informs learners that speaking or writing in business contexts involves performing a number of typical discourse acts, such as requesting in business English letter writing and apologizing in handling business disputes. Take requesting for example, the teacher can use authentic business letters and business videos to remind learners that once a request is made in business letters, it will certainly trigger a chain reaction of personnel follow-up and resource allocation from the other party. A well-written business letter therefore requires careful and appropriate requests to effectively fulfill tasks or obtain things and information.

Step 2: Providing lexical-semantic resources for discourse acts based on local grammar analyses

Upon the learners' enhanced awareness of discourse acts in business contexts, the teacher further stresses that performing a discourse act requires a good command of a variety of lexical-semantic resources. The teacher can also illustrate this with requesting. First, it can be emphasized that for making appropriate requests in business letters, it is more useful to know who is requesting (i.e. 'Requester'), who is being requested (i.e. 'Requestee'), what has been requested (i.e. 'Requested action' or 'Intended action', etc.), and what typical words can be used to realize these meanings/functions. Based on our established local grammar of requesting, the teacher provides the lexical-semantic resources for requesting in the form of local grammar patterns (as in Table 21). Drawing on the authentic corpus data, the teacher illustrates how each local grammar pattern is realized in real business letters. For example, the corpus instance *Place one full-page ad each week* can be used to illustrate the pattern 'Requested action'. The authentic data in language classroom, "superior to invented or adapted data" (Sinclair, 2004, p. 5), can better inform business English teaching and the production of teaching resources. By providing learners an authentic inventory of lexical-semantic resources to perform a discourse act, local grammar, we argue, has high potential to help ESP/EBP learners develop their pragmalinguistic competence.

Step 3: Training the selection of patterns for changing contexts

As has been discussed in Section 5, each local grammar pattern fits a particular communicative context. For example, the pattern 'Requester + Hinge + Intended action' (e.g. *I want to be a part of your team*) works well when the requester needs to directly expresses demands. This means that local grammar patterns are sensitive to contexts. A full mastery of the patterns demands that the teacher train learners' ability to choose appropriate patterns for specific contexts. To do this, wider textual contexts need to be taken from the corpus to help the teacher and learners recognize specific communicative needs so as to look for suitable local grammar patterns to meet these needs accordingly. For example, when it is identified that a context needs the requester to obtain the other party's permission to do something, the teacher works together with the students to locate a pattern such as 'Indicator + Requested action + Requester + Intended action' (e.g. *Will you grant me an eight-month leave of absence?*) to deal with it. In fact, this step trains the ability to understand the constraints that social/contextual conditions exert on language use. Through contextual choices of language resources to deal with varying communicative situations, learners know better what contextual variables determine the appropriateness of a particular pragmalinguistic choice, which in turn develops their sociopragmatic competence.

Overall, it is argued that local grammar analyses, which make the lexical-semantic resources of a business discourse act and their contextual variation more accessible to learners of business English, might be more useful for cultivating their pragmatic competence in ESP/EBP contexts.

7. Conclusions

This study has adopted a local grammar approach to analyze the semantic patterns of the discourse act of requesting in English business letters. Our analyses showed that this discourse act involves eight meanings/functions, forming 16 recurrent local grammar patterns. These patterns represent the main lexical-semantic resources at business letter writers' disposal to perform requesting.

Based on our discussion, we argue that compared with other grammar approaches, the local grammar approach contributes important methodological insights for investigating ESP/EBP discourses: First, by focusing on one discourse act only at a time, local grammar provides an easy-to-handle approach to exploring patterning of language in ESP/EBP settings. Second, local grammar, with its focused language observation perspective and context-specific analytical terminologies, provides a finer-grained and targeted approach to exploring characteristic ESP/EBP language usage. Third, as local grammar analysis probes into how various micro meaning elements work together for a discourse act and as local grammar patterns are context-sensitive, the local grammar approach is in a better position to reveal the link between communicative needs and language resources. It in turn has strong potential to better inform ESP/EBP teaching. Fourth, through quantification of the semantic realizations of discourse acts, local grammar provides a more systematic analysis of functions/meanings in ESP/EBP discourses than other grammar approaches.

Our three-step business discourse act teaching method also provides important pedagogical implications for training learners' pragmatic competence in ESP/EBP contexts: First, training pragmatic competence in business English can start with arousing learners' awareness of the importance of business discourse acts. Second, the training involves developing learners' pragmalinguistic competence, i.e. providing a reliable inventory of lexical-semantic resources to perform discourse acts based on established local grammars of business discourse acts. Third, the training also includes cultivating learners' sociopragmatic competence by developing their ability to choose appropriate semantic patterns of a discourse act for a specific context.

This study has limitations. First, we have to acknowledge that the regrettable close down of the website of the Business Letter Corpus in 2022 weakens the replicability of this study. However, we think that the local grammar approach introduced in this study can still provide important methodological reference for investigating discourse acts in other corpora of business English in future studies. Second, as this study focuses on the explicitly expressed requests with conventionalized lexical markers (e.g. *you must* … , *could you* … , *I want to* …), we may have missed some instances of requesting that lack such explicit markers in corpus searching. All these deserve closer attention in future studies.

Declaration of competing interest

None

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Lei Zhang: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Methodology, Funding acquisition, Conceptualization. **Fuzhi Tong:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Software, Project administration, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Data curation.

Statement

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Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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